

now. Would he contemplate cutting, running, and selling out to avoid the market here? Not for a moment. There is nothing he would be less likely to do. Yes, he did lighten up on stocks several times in his ultra-long career, but only when he could know that the market hadn't fallen yet and still might, not after it had fallen, hoping it would fall still more.

Would my father fear Saddam Hussein, Osama bin Laden, or terrorists? No. Would he fear war? He tells you directly in these pages that he would not. Would he admire President Bush for pointing us toward war? No. He rarely admired presidents because he saw them as politicians and he came to not much care for politicians; and the few he ever cared for weren't so high up. He said, "The higher they go, the liar they get." And he hated war and rarely could see its justification. Would he have worried about the myriad of other negatives in contemporary media, like corporate integrity, double-dip recession possibilities, high market price-earnings ratios, the risk of Brazil defaulting, or whatever? No, not much. He would have used this time while others focused on the wrong things to refocus on the basic fundamentals of the firms he owned and to see if he should still own them. And in looking at the weakest among them, he would be contemplating if there were one or two better firms he could find somewhere to replace them. He always saw volatile, down markets as a great opportunity to upgrade the quality of his few stocks. And the more folks fretted about the market, the more he would be fretting about what he owned and didn't own.

Late in his career when asked about market timing or sector issues, he would say something like, "Well, my son has proven he can navigate those waters much better than I've ever been able to, and here is what he says . . . but, I still wouldn't trust him." He never trusted anyone to make those kinds of decisions for him. He trusted the ownership of firms that possessed his fifteen points to take care of him. And he would today.

Many times in my career, someone would tell me (a) that I was wrong (which may have been and always may be quite true) and (b) that my father never would have done what I'm doing. I would always know generally that this person clearly didn't know my father's brain one iota as well as I did and that he or she almost certainly hadn't read his writings as often as I had. So, I never much worried about people's assessment of what my father would and wouldn't have done. My point here is that even being the one who knew him best, in a business sense, I read him more than most. Even if